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TAB 14



Board of Education Report

File #: Rep-135-24/25, **Version:** 1

Request for Approval of 2025 Advocacy Agenda and Guiding Principles and Priorities
January 14, 2025
Office of Government Relations

Action Proposed:

Approval to sponsor legislation and proactively advocate for policies and funding proposals at the local, state and federal levels that are consistent with the District's 2022-26 Strategic Plan.

Background:

Each year the Office of Government Relations (OGR) presents to the Board proposed advocacy priorities for the upcoming year. This includes securing authors for legislation, advocating for changes/inclusion in budget and funding proposals, and taking positions on related bills, regulatory changes, and policy issues as presented on the attached documents. Given the unprecedented challenges the District has faced in recent years and the uncertainty that lies ahead, it will be important to build in flexibility to authorize the Office of Governmental Relations to pursue the necessary advocacy on other policy and funding priorities as new issues arise in 2025.

Expected Outcomes:

The approved policy and funding priorities will result in a coherent advocacy agenda that the Office of Governmental Relations will promote and advance by building local and state coalitions with a diverse set of education partners.

Board Options and Consequences:

Approval will allow OGR staff to proceed in a timely manner to secure authors for legislation and pursue advocacy with the various levels of government. Delay in approval will negatively impact the securing of authors for legislation prior to the legislative deadlines for the introduction of bills.

Policy Implications:

The Advocacy Agenda and Guiding Principles and Priorities support existing Board policies and are in alignment with the District's 2022-26 Strategic Plan.

Budget Impact:

Costs of the proposal are borne by OGR within the existing general fund budget.

Student Impact:

The Advocacy Agenda and Guiding Principles and Priorities support students and their academic achievement either directly or indirectly through legislation and policies. Advocacy on behalf of the Los Angeles Unified community is critical to the success of students, teachers and administrators, and the advancement of our schools.

Equity Impact:

Not Applicable

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Issues and Analysis:

Not Applicable

Attachments:

Attachment A: Los Angeles Unified: 2025 Advocacy Agenda

Attachment B: Los Angeles Unified: 2025 Advocacy Guiding Principles and Priorities

Informatives:

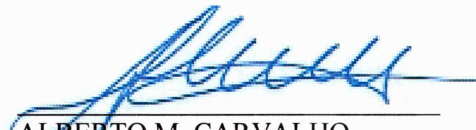
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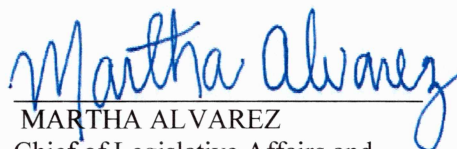
12/09/24

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RESPECTFULLY SUBMITTED,


ALBERTO M. CARVALHO
Superintendent

APPROVED & PRESENTED BY:


MARTHA ALVAREZ
Chief of Legislative Affairs and
Government Relations
Office of Government Relations

REVIEWED BY:


DEVORA NAVERA REED
General Counsel

☒ Approved as to form.

REVIEWED BY:


NOLBERTO DELGADILLO
Deputy Chief Business Officer, Finance

☒ Approved as to budget impact statement.



Los Angeles Unified School District

2025 ADVOCACY AGENDA

ADVOCACY PRIORITIES

The Los Angeles Unified School District's (Los Angeles Unified) legislative and funding priorities call for policies that make schools safe, welcoming, and equitable places for learning. The 2025 Advocacy Agenda is aligned to Los Angeles Unified's 2022-26 Strategic Plan and the District's Advocacy Guiding Principles and Priorities. In addition to the issues identified below, the Office of Government Relations supports and advocates for legislative proposals and initiatives that are consistent with the Strategic Plan and will pursue necessary policies and funding in 2025 as new issues arise.

LOCAL

The Office of Government Relations, in collaboration with other District departments and Region Offices, will explore opportunities for partnerships with local municipalities serving District schools to address the following:

- Strengthen intergovernmental collaboration to expand the District's enrollment campaign efforts and support school-aged children who are not enrolled or attending school.
- Support efforts to address the synthetic opioid crisis and access to illicit substances.
- Strengthen partnership with Los Angeles County to unify mental health funding and staffing to provide consistent services for schools and communities in high-need areas.
- Increase resources to support a positive school climate and safe routes to and from schools.
- Support efforts aimed at the relocation or closure of the Atlas facility site in Watts and explore funding opportunities for site clean-up.
- Expand joint-use facilities agreements and programming for students through continued partnerships with regional Recreation and Parks departments.
- Establish new and implement existing education compacts with local governments.

STATE

The Office of Government Relations will pursue the following statewide legislation and budget priorities, and engage in policy proposals consistent with the Guiding Principles and Priorities:

Sponsored Legislation

- Revise opt-in/consent requirements of vision and dental screenings for unhoused students.
- Increase flexibility to allow students in continuation schools to pursue work-based learning and other educational opportunities.
- Create permanent authorization for Best Value Procurement contracting method.
- Revise fiscal penalty calculation related to certain requirements in universal Transitional Kindergarten.

State Budget Priorities

- Maintain or increase the projected cost of living adjustment (COLA) for FY 2025-26.
- Protect LCFF and maintain flexibility and local control through avoidance of additional categorical programs.
- Participate in discussions as to the most impactful uses of the Proposition 98 funding “dividend” resulting from declining enrollment.
- Amend universal Transitional Kindergarten penalties, and fully fund required TK ratio and class size requirements.
- Expand funding for special education services by increasing the reimbursement rate for students with moderate to severe disabilities.
- Support investments in school facilities construction, modernization, and greening projects.
- Maintain Targeted Instructional and Improvement (TIIG) Funding.

FEDERAL

The Office of Government Relations will continue to advocate for the following issues at the federal level:

- Work with partners to protect and support newcomers, immigrant students and families, including support for permanent legal protections and a pathway to citizenship for undocumented youth.
- Additional funding to increase access to high-quality preschool programs for all 3- and 4-year-olds, including support for increased reimbursement rates, teacher preparation programs, and facilities renovations.
- Continue to work with national partners and build support for the bipartisan IDEA Full Funding Act.
- Increase connectivity funding to provide students and teachers access to devices and internet services for off-campus use and support changes to the E-Rate program to use funds to strengthen IT security infrastructure.
- Advocate for increased spending for special education, Title I, Title II, Title III, Title IV, and Magnet Schools Assistance grants in the annual FY 2025 and FY 2026 spending bills.
- Support and explore programs, partnerships and legislation that combat homelessness and remove barriers to success for unhoused youth.
- Advocate for the federal recognition of the Gabrielino Tongva and Fernandeño Tataviam Band of Mission Indians as the First People of Los Angeles County.



OFFICE OF GOVERNMENTAL RELATIONS 2025 ADVOCACY GUIDING PRINCIPLES AND PRIORITIES

As the second largest school district in the nation, the Los Angeles Unified School District (Los Angeles Unified) serves a diverse community of more than 500,000 students in pre-Kindergarten through Adult Education. Los Angeles Unified families speak 98 languages in their households. Over 86 percent of our students are identified as low-income, English Learner, and/or in the foster care system. These students demonstrate extraordinary resilience and persistence, constantly striving to overcome the challenges they face. Supporting the academic achievement and social-emotional well-being of students, and closing educational equity gaps, requires strong partnerships with federal, state, and local governments.

The Office of Governmental Relations (OGR) informs the Board and the Superintendent of legislative developments and opportunities, and responds to advocacy priorities identified by the Board, the Superintendent and District staff. These guiding principles frame the advocacy and engagement that OGR undertakes on behalf of Los Angeles Unified, and guide OGR's work when evaluating legislation or funding proposals introduced by governmental entities, particularly the California Legislature. OGR will consider opposing or seeking amendments to legislation that contradicts the following guiding principles or undermines the District's discretion to adopt local policies that best serve the interest of students.

GUIDING PRINCIPLES

Los Angeles Unified's principles are guided by the five Pillars of our 2022-26 Strategic Plan, as well as a focus on equity, fiscal responsibility, and local control.

Academic Excellence

Students' academic achievement is essential to forming a meaningful path to college and career. A culture of academic achievement and high expectations spurs student curiosity and engagement and prepares students to participate in civil society and democracy. The State must continue to advance efforts to address opportunity gaps and chronic absenteeism. In alignment with our Strategic Plan, we will support efforts that allow us to improve student performance and graduation rates, so that all students graduate ready for the world.

Joy and Wellness

Student health and wellbeing anchors the core of everything we do as a district. All policies we sponsor or support must serve our students' ability to learn, grow, and thrive in a safe environment that helps them achieve their greatest potential as scholars and citizens. As part of this effort, we will support policies that are consistent with the principles of educational equity and that prioritize access to limited resources in areas of highest need.

Engagement and Collaboration

Building trust among internal and external community partners is a critical step in supporting the needs of students. OGR remains committed to strengthening communication with parents and

external partners on the District’s advocacy efforts, and to solicit support on advocacy priorities where coalition efforts are warranted.

Operational Effectiveness and Investing in Staff

As the second largest employer in Los Angeles County and second largest public education system in the country, Los Angeles Unified is committed to ensuring the organizational sustainability of the school district by supporting an educator and staff pipeline of highly qualified and diverse personnel. We will advocate for flexibilities that allow the District to prioritize positions that support services for the whole child, and oppose legislation that takes away the District’s discretion to meet the students’ best interest and contradicts the District’s Strategic Plan initiatives.

Fiscal Responsibility

Recognizing that California has a requirement to present a balanced state budget, we will holistically consider how requests for increased state or federal funding for certain programs may impact other District advocacy priorities. We believe that it is important that the State fund any new mandates or requirements that it places on school districts. As a large and diverse district, we value flexibility in funding and protecting the principles of the Local Control Funding Formula (LCFF), and will explore and respond to options suggested for structural changes to the LCFF. We will continue to advocate for sustainable, ongoing funding that allows the District to invest in our students, staff and families over the long term.

Local Control

Los Angeles Unified is a unique district within California and the United States. Our student body is over four times larger than the next largest district in the State and offers services “in-house” that in most districts are supported by their County Office of Education. We recognize and respect that each district serves a unique population and faces unique challenges. For that reason, we value local control and local discretion to determine curriculum, provide services and administer programs according to local student needs wherever possible.

AREAS OF FOCUS

Adequacy of Funding

Serving students requires investing in a full and fair funding strategy that includes investments in preschool through Adult Education. The Legislature should consider that costs, such as health insurance and housing, are rising far above the rate of inflation, since the annual cost-of-living-adjustment (COLA) is often insufficient. We will continue to advocate for California to join most states in funding schools based on student enrollment, rather than attendance, which more accurately reflects the fixed costs of serving students. Further, the state legislature should prioritize the reimbursements of costly mandated activities that result in less discretionary funding for school sites and the classroom. Los Angeles Unified is opposed to reductions or eliminations of the Targeted Instructional Improvement Block Grant (TIIG) funding.

As enrollment declines, per pupil funding in Proposition 98 likely will increase, creating a dividend that can be invested in different ways. We will be actively engaged in conversations about the best possible uses of this funding, and associated changes to the LCFF structure.

Adult Education

Adult Education provides English as a Second Language (ESL), basic skills, high school diploma, and career technical education classes to adults and out-of-school teens to help them reach their college, career, and community goals. To expand and improve services to effectively meet the needs of adult learners, we will support state policies that provide flexibility in addressing changing workforce needs and increase community access to adult education programs and services.

Charter Schools

We support legislative efforts that support all authorizers in the state to advance strong oversight, particularly in the areas of academic achievement, governance, and fiscal transparency, as well as accountability for charter school operations, and equity and access for all students. As the largest authorizer in the State, we believe charter authorizers across the state need to receive ongoing levels of support to implement effective oversight.

Curriculum and Instruction

Robust instructional supports are essential contributors to student success. We will advocate for state support of curriculum and instructional practices by ensuring that sufficient resources are available to effectively implement new and existing curriculum requirements and practices. The State should promote the development of robust curriculum frameworks and additions integrated into existing frameworks, while remaining mindful of the impact that new curriculum requirements have on graduation rates, student enrichment opportunities, and the ability of local school boards to design a curriculum that meets local needs and preferences. Given the addition of two new graduation requirements in recent years, we call upon the Legislature to avoid any new requirements without considering which existing requirements can be removed or consolidated. In addition, the COVID-19 pandemic created new ways of delivering instruction. We support efforts to maintain and expand access to online tutoring, virtual learning and coursework, and other digital resources.

Before and After School Programs

With the creation of the Expanded Learning Opportunities Program, school districts can better support working families and expand learning opportunities for students, including access to arts, music, sports, enrichment activities, and field trips that would be otherwise out of reach for many students. We are committed to continuing to strengthen before- and after-school program coherence, quality, developmental appropriateness, and accessibility. We will advocate for ongoing dedicated support for before- and after-school programming and appropriate reimbursement rates to continue these programs.

Data-Driven Practices

Academic achievement and post-secondary success can be achieved most readily when targeted instruction and intervention are guided by real-time, multiple-measure data, both qualitative and quantitative, across transitions from pre-kindergarten to elementary; elementary to middle; middle to high school; and high school to college or career. The State should invest in and support local education agencies' ability to monitor effectiveness and guide technical assistance. We believe that the State should hold schools accountable for metrics that are actionable and should avoid penalizing districts or creating the perception of lower performance for activities or outcomes out

of their control. When the State identifies schools to receive additional assistance, the State should also provide timely and transparent policies for how schools will exit this identification for support.

Digital Equity and Safety

Access to high-speed and reliable internet has proven to be a necessity—not a luxury—allowing students, families, and businesses to access valuable information online to continue instruction, stay socially connected, and complete daily work. The digital divide is especially harmful to public education in low-income communities and communities of color which are disproportionately impacted, leaving the highest-need families disconnected. The State recently adopted a Digital Equity Bill of Rights and must go further to ensure that these principles are translated into action by supporting affordable, reliable, high-speed broadband, and by building out middle-mile and last-mile infrastructure to underserved areas. We also recognize that technologies can negatively affect student health, safety, and wellness. Both State and Federal governments must enhance social media safety and protect students from social media-related dangers including cyberbullying, hate speech, sexual harassment, and propaganda; and by implementing policies that allow schools to effectively manage the use of smart phones and social media on campus. We recognize that cyberattacks threaten our networks and will continue to work with state and federal authorities to protect our network assets, information, and community against increasingly sophisticated cyber criminals. Finally, we are attentive to both the opportunities and challenges inherent to the rise of Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) and will be a voice for students as state guidelines, policies and regulations are developed.

Early Childhood Education

High-quality pre-Kindergarten and Transitional Kindergarten programs improve a child's social-emotional development and lead to stronger mathematics and literacy skills. Los Angeles Unified is committed to providing every student with a quality education and believes in laying the foundation early to prepare children for kindergarten and beyond. We will support policies that expand access to high-quality early learning for children ages 0-5, including, but not limited to, the implementation of the alternative reimbursement rate system, greater supports to increase the quality and preparation of the workforce, the creation of Kindergarten as a mandatory grade and the removal of administrative barriers that prevent eligible children from accessing the programs. The State must ensure that new or more stringent program requirements are funded before those requirements are implemented, and that districts are provided sufficient time and resources to implement any new requirements such as smaller class size ratios and increased teacher qualifications. We advocate for the reduction of overly rigid and inequitable penalties in programs that impede program quality by reducing funding for all students because of minor infractions.

English Learners and Language Acquisition

We will support policies that allow English Learners to acquire English fluency and reclassify as English proficient while maintaining their home language and graduating college- and career-ready with the California Seal of Biliteracy. We will seek to expand dual language education programming and offer world language classes that reflect the diversity of our district, and to provide multilingual pathways for all students to become bilingual and biliterate.

Federal Policies

With the support of our federal advocates, we will continue to monitor and advocate through the annual appropriations cycle for increased funding of Titles I-IV formula programs; federal grant programs such as the Magnet Schools Assistance (MSA) grant; and 21st Century program funds for after-school programs. In addition, we will actively advocate for full funding of the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA); passage of federal legislation to fund schools' physical and digital infrastructure, including school greening projects; the repeal of the Government Pension Offset/Windfall Elimination Provision and increased funding to state and local education agencies under the McKinney-Vento Homeless Assistance Act.

We will support a permanent solution for undocumented youth and Temporary Protected Status (TPS) beneficiaries, and the end of immigration policies that impact learning and family stability. We will oppose efforts to create Federal laws, policies, or practices that require school districts to cooperate with Federal agencies and immigration personnel in any way related to immigration enforcement action.

We will advocate for additional funding to increase access to high-quality preschool programs for all 3- and 4-year-olds, including support for increased reimbursement rates, teacher preparation programs and facilities renovations. We will seek to increase connectivity funding to provide students and teachers with access to devices and internet services for off-campus use and support changes to the E-Rate program to use funds to strengthen IT security infrastructure. We will continue to support and explore programs, partnerships and legislation that combat homelessness and remove barriers to success for unhoused youth. We will continue to support efforts to promote common-sense gun reform. We will also advocate for federal recognition of the Gabrielino-Tongva and Fernandeño Tataviam tribes. In addition to these priorities, we will support federal legislation that is consistent with other policies and principles outlined in this document, as appropriate.

Post-Secondary Attainment and Success

College readiness curriculum, providing access to the financial aid application process, and concurrent enrollment at secondary school sites builds students' identity as college and career ready. Los Angeles Unified is committed to preparing all students for postsecondary success by supporting state policies that enable us to align innovative resources equitably and effectively in support of student needs. We will support policies that remove barriers to college access for all students, especially those from underrepresented communities.

School Facilities

With over 1,300 schools serving pre-kindergarten through Adult Education, Los Angeles Unified's aging and deteriorated school facilities require ongoing investments to provide safe, healthy, and functional places to learn for all students. We are still making up for decades of unmet capital needs, while new requirements and priorities emerge, and the backlog of unaddressed conditions continues to grow. Los Angeles Unified has \$80 billion of identified unfunded school facility needs and over 60% of its school buildings are over 50 years old. We are committed to pursuing and supporting changes to state law that will maximize funding, address barriers to timely project execution, ensure efficient use of resources, and promote the District's climate goals including the transition to renewable energy. We support statewide investments in school facilities construction,

modernization, and greening projects, and will pursue actions that enable us to upgrade our solar power system to achieve 100 percent clean renewable energy by 2030.

School Personnel Pipeline

With the ongoing need to create a pipeline of credentialed math and science teachers, nurses, psychiatric social workers, librarians, administrators, and other certificated and classified positions, we will continue to advocate for programs that expand career ladders, both pre-service and in-service, and draw highly effective candidates into the field of education. These efforts include funding for teacher preparation programs, higher education collaboratives between districts and institutions of higher education, and research practice partnerships.

Special Education

Special education is significantly underfunded in California and across the nation. The share of District's General Fund contribution directed to special education is more than double the State or federal share. We believe the State and federal governments need to increase their investment levels to enhance equitable special education funding for pre-Kindergarten students with disabilities and students with moderate –to severe disabilities. We will continue to support federal funding efforts to match the initial principles of the IDEA to fund special education at the appropriate level. We support the principles of inclusiveness and inclusive terminology.

State Mandates

The passage of state legislation often results in new, unfunded mandates that local educational agencies pay out of the existing state funding received through the Local Control Funding Formula. With the passage of new legislation, the state legislature should prioritize the reimbursements of costly mandated activities that result in less discretionary funding for school sites and the classroom. The State must meet its obligations to reimburse school districts for prior mandate claims and should develop a clear and public process for the funding of future state-mandated activities – either through the constitutional claim process, or inclusion in the K-12 Mandate Block Grant Program.

Student Safety

Student safety is one of Los Angeles Unified's top priorities. The District takes a strong position against bullying, hazing, or any behavior that infringes on the safety or well-being of students, employees, or any other persons within the District's jurisdiction or interferes with learning or the ability to teach. We will collaborate with local authorities, including the City of Los Angeles, other local municipalities within the District's boundaries and the County of Los Angeles, to support safe passage to and from school for students, staff and families. We will advocate for full funding for crossing guards and traffic calming measures that reduce pedestrian-related incidents. As our nation faces an unprecedented threat to our youth in synthetic opioid overdose risk, we will support efforts at all levels of government to address this crisis. We will also advocate for new avenues to curtail the pervasive epidemic of gun violence through new legislative requirements, including, but not limited to, strengthening gun violence restraining orders, gun storage laws, restrictions of the sale of firearms and increased safety measures.

Supporting the Whole Child

Supporting the whole child is grounded on the principle that each student's potential for success is positively influenced by an environment that fosters the health, mental health, safety, engagement, support, and academic enrichment of that student. Students learn best when we recognize that academic achievement is not limited to experiences in the classroom. Accordingly, we will continue to advocate for whole-child well-being, including, but not limited to, expanding services for the health and wellness of students through Medi-Cal and other funding mechanisms, supporting ongoing funding for Community Schools, following up with engagement on statewide one-time funding sources, and supporting measures that combat homelessness in our community and remove barriers to success for homeless youth. We will continue expanding our network of medical, mental, and behavioral health services through internal and external providers. We will support policies and programs that affirm our LGBTQ+ students and oppose efforts that cause harm to their mental health, safety, and wellbeing. We will continue to expand access to sustainable funding for provision of school meals that meet federal and state nutritional standards and support measures that contribute access to affordable housing for students, families, and school employees.